

feature requests, or interact with it in a broader way. Doing so not only boosts visibility around your open source project, but can also help foster a sense of community that is strong within the world of open source.

Define your marketing goals

You have a project, and its goal is probably very clear to you, but the goal of your marketing efforts will be different than the goal of your project. For example, are you looking to attract contributors, engage code reviewers, or simply expand your user base? Each of these goals will have overlapping tactics, but if you pick one and focus on that when making all your decisions, you will find that your effort is far more fruitful.

Regardless of whether you hope to drive downloads or increase visibility, it is crucial to ensure your goals are measurable and aligned with the broader mission of your project. This will help define the strategy and channels you use to accomplish your goals.

For example, if you are hoping to gain users, more than specifically contributors, then you can focus on broadcasting -- blog posts, video demos, submitting talks to conferences or topic ideas to podcasts, etc. If you want to gain contributors, you can focus on outlining a list of feature ideas or bug reports, along with plenty of documentation about how to fix those things. You can then start highlighting new contributors wherever you can and setting up a place for potential contributors to gather (a chat room or the like). You may also consider finding a place where experts and beginners in your chosen language look for help (akin to *this-week-in-rust.org* for Rust programmers).

Invite feedback through contributor guides

Publicising any project inevitably invites feedback and opens the door for diverse perspectives that can uncover blind spots, identify areas of

improvement, and even validate the usefulness of your project efforts. Such a perspective is crucial to the success of the project, but the way feedback is given and received can greatly impact its effectiveness.

Guiding feedback using a contributor guide can help serve as a blueprint for fostering constructive feedback and collaboration within your project community. Define early how you want your users to provide feedback, and your contributors to send in pull requests, and then document those definitions! Make liberal use of templates for issues and pull requests and define your anticipated feedback timelines. If you get time to engage with your users only once a week, make sure that is stated (maybe even set up an auto-reply bot stating such) so that folks don't feel ignored.

The value of your project and your efforts is worth setting yourself up for success ahead of time. By creating an environment where thoughtful and respectful critiques and comments can be given, transparency and openness within your community can be encouraged.

Build awareness

Building awareness around your project can come with a variety of marketable ideas and strategies to best present your efforts to the public. While word of mouth is one of the most tried and trusted ways to generate attention, the shift to social media and web presence has placed marketing emphasis elsewhere. Blogs, vlogs, and podcast appearances are excellent opportunities to not only showcase your project's potential but to really dive deep into its history, the problems that it can solve, and the value it provides.

Welcome diverse voices

Building awareness can be enhanced by welcoming a diverse set of voices to your project. With any project that requires personal time and investment, it can be hard to open the doors to

a variety of opinions, critiques, and alternate perspectives. But open source communities are colourful and vibrant ecosystems where diverse individuals come together to share ideas, drive innovation, and inspire each other. This is the time to check your ego at the door, ensure that YOU are a good community steward, and let the success of the project take the lead.

At the same time, though, it is still your project! Set realistic expectations and times for the people who do engage with you and be consistent in your application of the things you've designed. Failing to do so can breed a lack of trust and discourage earnest engagement with you and your team.

Take care of your project

If you have done all this perfectly, then you have brought in users and contributors, been consistent in your engagement with those users, and have built trust with a growing community. You are using your platforms to discuss the things you would like to see expanded or the new and exciting ways your project is being used. Your code reviewers also use this space to highlight the problems within the project or with community engagement overall. Well done!

If you haven't done this already, that's okay too! I can't think of a single project that has executed this perfectly ahead of time, and hasn't hit some snags along the way. But, by slowing down, drawing up a detailed checklist and taking the time to do the leg work early in the process, you can avoid feeling left behind later. 

Reference

- <https://opensource.org/>

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